Brief minutes of that day's meeting identified the topic of discussion as "On Assistance to Cuba," suggesting that Khrushchev framed the discussion as one about saving Cuba rather than addressing the lack of parity in the Soviet and American nuclear arsenals and missile capabilities. Vladimir Malin, the head of the Central Committee's General Department, who kept an informal record of the meeting, scribbled in his notes: "How to help Cuba so that it holds out." Judging by Malin's notes, no one objected to Khrushchev's solution to the problem. But according to another notetaker, the secretary of the Defense Council, Colonel General Semen Ivanov, there was at least one dissenter, Khrushchev's first deputy in the Council of Ministers, Anastas Mikoyan, who voiced his objections to the idea of "placing our missiles and troops on Cuba."[2]

Khrushchev spoke with Mikoyan before the meeting and knew about his objections to the missile plan. Mikoyan was anxious that once the Americans learned about the missiles, they would not tolerate such a proximate threat of nuclear attack and would strike the missile sites, killing Soviet troops there. "What are we supposed to do in such a case—respond with a strike on US soil?" asked Mikoyan. Khrushchev did not disagree. "I had expressed the same idea as well," recalled Khrushchev of one of his discussions with Mikoyan. "I even said that such a step, roughly speaking, was on the verge of being reckless. The recklessness of the plan was that our desire to defend Cuba could lead to an unprecedented nuclear war. We needed to find ways to avoid it by any means, because a deliberate initiation of such a war would definitely be reckless adventurism." Khrushchev knew that he was risking war, and nuclear war at that, but believed that he could get away with his reckless step.

Khrushchev tried to get Mikoyan on his side but failed. "What if we send our missiles there and deploy them quickly and unnoticeably?" he asked Mikoyan at a private meeting after his return from Bulgaria. "Then we will notify the Americans about it, first through diplomatic channels and then publicly. That will put them in their place. They will be put in a position of the same balance of forces as with our country. Any aggression against Cuba will mean a strike on American territory. They will have to give up any plans of an invasion of Cuba." Mikoyan was unconvinced by what he heard. "I told him that it was dangerous," he recalled later. "Such